maintain, open or establish any store in this State without first having obtained a license . . ."

It would violate every principle of statutory construction to hold that this plain language really means that individuals and small local corporations are not within the intendment of the Act, but that it in fact applies only to so-called giant corporations. To attribute such a covert, hidden, and indirect purpose to those who passed the statute is, in effect, to charge the lawmakers with saying one thing and meaning another. Nothing said in *O'Gorman & Young* v. *Hartford Fire Insurance Co.*, 282 U. S. 251, or any other decision of this court, justifies such a pronouncement. The legislature of Florida has declared the purpose and object of the statute to be to tax every store owner and operator, and we should not go behind that declaration and attribute to the lawmakers some other ulterior design. Corporations are as much entitled to the equal protection of the laws guaranteed by the Fourteenth Amendment as are natural persons. *Southern Ry. Co.* v. *Greene,* 216 U. S. 400; *Kentucky Finance Corp.* v. *Paramount Exchange,* 262 U. S. 544; *Power Mfg. Co.* v. *Saunders,* 274 U. S. 490; *Liggett Co.* v. *Baldridge,* 278 U. S. 105; *Iowa-Des Moines National Bank* v. *Bennett,* 284 U. S. 239. Unequal treatment and arbitrary discrimination as between corporations and natural persons, or between different corporations, inconsistent with the declared object of the legislation, cannot be justified by the assumption that a different classification for a wholly different purpose might be valid.

Those provisions of § 5 which increase the tax if the owner's stores are located in more than one county are unreasonable and arbitrary, and violate the guaranties of the Fourteenth Amendment.

3. Section 11 of the act provides:

"A County license tax of twenty-five per cent of the State license tax shall be levied and imposed upon each